

The Sustainable Development Goals – SDG#11 Sustainable Cities and Communities

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Chapter 1

The Sustainable Development Goals – SDG#11 Sustainable Cities and Communities

Rob Hales and Naomi Birdthistle

Introduction

The 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, adopted by all member states of the United Nations in 2015, is a shared blueprint for people and the planet, with the aim to achieve peace and prosperity for all. The Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) is a call to action, to develop innovative solutions to some of the world's most complex, societal and environmental challenges. Businesses play a crucial role in forging this path, and since family businesses account for more than two-thirds of businesses worldwide and contribute to 70%–90% of the world's GDP, we believe it is important to showcase the role they play in facilitating the achievement of these SDGs.

The 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development is a call to action for all countries to address the global challenges of poverty, inequality, climate change, environmental degradation, peace and justice. These challenges are identified by 17 SDGs as depicted in [Fig. 1](#), and within the SDGs are a total of 169 targets. These 17 SDGs acknowledge that ending poverty and other global challenges need strategies that improve health and education, reduce inequality and spur economic growth – all while tackling climate change and working to preserve our oceans and forests ([United Nations, 2021](#)).

This book makes an important contribution to research on family businesses by highlighting how businesses can make valuable contributions towards sustainable development. There are several streams of research emerging in the literature on family business and sustainability that are relevant to this book. [Ferreira et al. \(2021\)](#) identify four streams of research in family business and sustainability: family business capital, family business strategy, family business social responsibility and

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Fig. 1. 17 Sustainable Development Goals. *Source:* [United Nations \(2021\)](#).¹

family business succession. The case study approach of this book provides insights into how SDGs can be used to advance the family business's sustainability strategy and social responsibility. How a family's trans-generational sustainability intentions positively influence the strategy of the business and the family's concern for its reputation has been identified as a driver of sustainability in family businesses. Additionally, family businesses routinely combine innovation and tradition to achieve and maintain a sustainable competitive advantage.

During the COVID-19 pandemic, many family businesses have shown to be more resilient and operate more sustainably than standard businesses (such as the shareholder approach). The reason for this lies in family businesses generally taking a long-term perspective on stakeholder relationships and the real need for long-term continuity planning to sustain the people within their businesses. The people in their business are most likely to be family members. However, like all businesses, the COVID-19 pandemic has placed financial pressures on family businesses. One needs to ask the question: *How then can family businesses extend their capacity to operate more sustainably and with more social impact during times of business stress?* Well, family businesses can offer unique insights into how sustainability and social impact can be part of the regenerative response to the impacts of the COVID-19 pandemic. The idea for the book came from two observations. The first observation was that family businesses that had sustainability at their core were performing well despite the impacts of the pandemic. The second observation was that the SDGs were being used as a framework for regeneration after the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic.

¹The content of this publication has not been approved by the United Nations and does not reflect the views of the United Nations or its officials or member states.

The global pandemic of COVID-19 has presented challenges to those working towards achieving the goals. The social and economic impacts of COVID-19 are predicted to increase the divide between people living in rich and poor countries (UNEP, 2020). However, if there can be concerted action using the blueprint of the SDGs, then human development can exceed pre-COVID development trajectories (UNEP, 2021). What is needed is a combination of political commitment from all levels of government, investment in green economy initiatives, socially oriented innovation and a (re)focus on the purpose of business to align with SDGs.

Book Series Focus – SDG#11

This book focuses on SDG number 11 (SDG#11), which focuses on making cities and human settlements inclusive, safe, resilient and sustainable. The main targets within SDG#11 are shown in Table 1.

Table 1. SDG#11 Targets.

Target 11.1	By 2030, ensure access for all to adequate, safe and affordable housing and basic services and upgrade slums
Target 11.2	By 2030, provide access to safe, affordable, accessible and sustainable transport systems for all, improving road safety, notably by expanding public transport, with special attention to the needs of those in vulnerable situations, women, children, persons with disabilities and older persons
Target 11.3	By 2030, enhance inclusive and sustainable urbanisation and capacity for participatory, integrated and sustainable human settlement planning and management in all countries
Target 11.4	Strengthen efforts to protect and safeguard the world's cultural and natural heritage
Target 11.5	By 2030, significantly reduce the number of deaths and the number of people affected and substantially decrease the direct economic losses relative to global gross domestic product caused by disasters, including water-related disasters, with a focus on protecting the poor and people in vulnerable situations
Target 11.6	By 2030, reduce the adverse per capita environmental impact of cities, including by paying special attention to air quality and municipal and other waste management
Target 11.7	By 2030, provide universal access to safe, inclusive and accessible, green and public spaces, in particular for women and children, older persons and persons with disabilities

Table 1. (Continued)

Target 11.a	Support positive economic, social and environmental links between urban, peri-urban and rural areas by strengthening national and regional development planning
Target 11.b	By 2020, substantially increase the number of cities and human settlements adopting and implementing integrated policies and plans towards inclusion, resource efficiency, mitigation and adaptation to climate change, resilience to disasters, and develop and implement, in line with the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction 2015–2030, holistic disaster risk management at all levels
Target 11.c	Support least developed countries, including through financial and technical assistance, in building sustainable and resilient buildings utilizing local materials

Source: [United Nations \(n.d.\)](#).

Government and private enterprises have different realms of actions within their mission of making significant contributions to SDG#11. Private enterprise is primarily interested in providing transportation, housing and waste management services, while governments focus on addressing governing risk through planning, reducing pollution and the greening of public spaces ([Asiamah & Sedegah, 2022](#)). For private enterprises, the targets and indicators listed in [Table 1](#) can be translated to business activity through the strategic alignment of the goals and actions of a particular business. The targets and indicators align with many sustainability-oriented initiatives and strategies in business. Some of the areas of focus include:

1. Focusing on implementing sustainable practices that have a wide impact in the places where a business operates: Businesses can reduce their environmental impact by adopting sustainable practices such as using renewable energy sources, minimising waste and reducing greenhouse gas emissions.
2. Investing in sustainable infrastructure: Businesses can invest in sustainable infrastructure such as public transport, green buildings and renewable energy to promote sustainable urbanisation.
3. Constructing sustainable infrastructure: When companies are part of infrastructure development, they can align their operation and outcomes with sustainability principles and SDG targets.
4. Collaborating with local communities to advance the SDG targets: Companies can work with local communities to understand their needs and develop solutions that meet their needs while promoting sustainability.
5. Support policy development: Businesses can support policy development and advocacy efforts aimed at promoting sustainable urbanisation and reducing environmental degradation.

6. Businesses focusing on risk reduction: Decreasing the vulnerability of communities to the impacts of climate change and other natural disasters means businesses can assist in risk reduction and resilience building.
7. Reporting on SDG#11 and sustainability to assist sustainable communities: Companies can report on their sustainability efforts, including their progress towards achieving SDG#11, to increase transparency and accountability.

The above list provides a framework for how family businesses can focus and potentially repurpose strategies to achieve sustainability actions that align with the SDGs. Progressive family businesses that have a focus on sustainability and social responsibility are likely to already be focusing on such priorities but may not realise they contribute to a country's SDG targets and in particular SDG#11.

Challenges facing businesses in the achievement of SDG#11 are many. Firstly, the rapid growth of cities is a major challenge for businesses making a significant contribution towards SDG#11. The growth of cities places significant pressure on essential services such as housing, water and sanitation. Business efforts to decrease these impacts can seem negligible when compared to the growing pressure and consequent overcrowding, inadequate infrastructure and environmental degradation. Not only is there a material issue in that gains made towards SDG#11 seem insurmountable, but there is also the issue of measurement. SDG#11 is a particularly difficult goal to measure through its somewhat nonspecific targets (Berisha et al., 2022).

Secondly, significant challenges are presented by climate change. The effects of climate change, such as rising sea levels, extreme weather events and heatwaves, can have a significant impact on cities and human settlements. Businesses that align with the target of SDG#11 need to implement strategies to mitigate the impacts of climate change, such as building risk-informed – resilient infrastructure (Sharma & Soederberg, 2020).

Third, financing the infrastructure aligned with SDG#11 requires a significant focus on the materiality of benefits and the minimisation of negative impacts. This can be challenging for many countries that face development issues, and thus businesses within these countries are either not regulated to direct SDG outcomes or do not have the resources to voluntarily commit to SDGs and their outcomes. Mobilising adequate resources to support sustainable development is crucial to achieving SDG#11 (Zhan & Santos-Paulino, 2021).

Implementing SDG#11 requires a coordinated effort from governments, civil society and the private sector. Addressing these challenges will require innovative solutions and sustained commitment to promoting sustainable development.

The Book Chapters

The book series aims to contribute positively to providing evidence of the role of family businesses in effectively contributing to all SDGs. The case studies on a family business display support and embody the principles of an SDG in their operations, culture and/or business philosophy. The book is 1 of 17 vignette book series in which each book is comprised of a set of short, easy-to-read family business cases related to the unique SDG being discussed in the book. The format

of the book series allows the works to be accessible to those working in the field beyond academia, such as family business practitioners, family business owners, family business advisors, government and business policymakers, members of NGOs, business associations and philanthropic centres, as well as to those who have a general interest in entrepreneurship and business.

The chapters in this book focus on businesses that have prioritised SDG#11 Sustainable Cities and Communities. Five businesses have been profiled in the book, and the first case profiles the company IQUTECH. It is Ireland's largest Returns Management Company. IQUTECH is a carbon-negative company that has grown to become one of Europe's leading Returns Management Consultancies providing solutions to Tier 1 manufacturing companies in sectors such as telecoms, consumer electronics, automotive and power. IQUTECH is a Circular Economy Enabler – by repairing and refurbishing returned electrical products and expanding their lifecycle on the market. IQUTECH has never set out to become a Circular Economy Enabler; the company has been only aiming to get the most out of all the materials that they were receiving. The family business doesn't label its business as an SDG-oriented business as it claims to have been doing sustainability for over 30 years. They are embarking on a process of measuring and publicly reporting on the SDG-aligned work. Having said this, IQUTECH has measured its impact and has managed to prevent approximately 240,000 electronic products from ending up in landfill or being left at customers' homes (IQUTECH, 2023). This is aligned with SDG#11.6.1 where IQUTECH contributes to reducing the amount of municipal solid waste collected through the repair of the products it receives. IQUTECH has future programs such as 'Take Back Schemes' and 'Food Banks' which have the purpose of giving products an alternative end use. The family business sees a bright future in 'urban mining', and they believe this will be a significant growth area and a vital element of future sustainability.

DINZLER Kaffeerösterei AG is a Bavarian family business with its headquarters in Irschenberg (located south of Munich). DINZLER Kaffeerösterei AG specialises in the roasting and distribution of premium coffee and tea and the distribution of high-quality coffee machines. DINZLER Kaffeerösterei AG is integrated into village structures in the Bavarian foothills of the Alps, and thus the SDG goals and their implications for entrepreneurial activities within these communities are also highly relevant. Some operational highlights of SDG#11 include returnable food packaging developed for major customers. Products are delivered in food-safe reusable containers that can be used many times and meet all hygienic standards through cleaning after each use. Another example includes the climate-neutral operation of coffee roasting in which an important part of this activity includes purchasing maximum-efficiency roasters that enable significant energy savings compared to the previous models by optimising the burner settings. DINZLER Kaffeerösterei AG is also conscious of its potential pollution in local communities and thus has implemented strict controls on production. These actions stem from a mission and business purpose which prioritises people and place. The coffee roasting business attaches great importance to ensuring that both guests and employees feel comfortable. This also includes a responsible approach to the surrounding nature.

The next chapter profiles a family business called Wolf Connection, which is a wolf sanctuary located on the outskirts of Acton, California, a rural town nestled

in the Angeles National Forest. Wolf Connection is an exemplary model of the UN's SDG#11, offering a sustained and long-term commitment to a number of the key aspects, notably SDG#11.a, which aims to provide a 'positive economic, social and environmental links between urban, peri-urban and rural areas'; SDG#11.4 which is to 'strengthen efforts to protect and safeguard the world's cultural and natural heritage'; and SDG#11.7 which is to 'provide universal access to safe, inclusive and accessible, green and public spaces, in particular for women and children, older persons and persons with disabilities'. The wolf sanctuary offers a range of diverse programs centred on different sections of the community, engaging with strategies for mental well-being and recovery. For example, there are therapy programs for at-risk youths and social integration and empowerment programs for women. The family business aligns with SDG#11 indicators 11.4.1 Protecting cultural heritage, SDG indicators 11.7.1 Open spaces in cities, and SDG indicators 11.7.1 Safe spaces in cities.

The second last chapter profiles the Shehada brothers. This family business owns several ventures in different sectors in the UAE. At present, the brothers run several businesses together. The businesses are spread in different sectors and include businesses focusing on events and entertainment, management consultancy, financial services and advisory, complete solutions for start-ups and small to medium enterprises (SMEs), corporate consultancy, strategy and research, property management and a construction company. This family business focuses on SDG#11 through a mentorship programme for young generations on sustainable and healthy living, aligning with SDG#11.7. They also support positive economic, social and environmental links between urban, peri-urban and rural areas by strengthening national and regional development planning, and the Shehada brothers are working to provide this support to the SMEs in the UAE. Specifically, they provide access to quality housing and basic services such as support in waste management, better air quality, structured transport system at the same time minimum harmful impact on the environment and residents. The chapter provides examples of how the business constructs inclusive developments by internalising energy costs, for the residents, of installing solar panels to reduce residents' reliance on grid electricity. The brothers believe that they are playing a part in achieving UAE's vision of developing sustainable cities and communities.

The last chapter is Hickinbotham Homes from Australia. This family business is a construction company that specialises in building new homes for customers. The company has an increased focus on sustainable building practices which are aligned with SDG#11. Hickinbotham Homes promote sustainability by offering sustainable features in their homes as standard products. These include solar panels, rainwater tanks and energy-efficient appliances which reduce energy and water usage and a smaller environmental footprint. The company has also expanded into larger sustainable developments and makes a locally significant contribution to SDG#11 targets ensuring access to affordable and sustainable urbanisation as well as reducing the environmental footprint of urbanisation. As part of SDG#11, there is a focus on minimising waste in the construction and development of urban areas. Hickinbotham Homes use recycled materials where possible and have implemented a waste management system that minimises waste and maximises recycling. The company also supports initiatives aimed at achieving greater sustainability and the SDGs, including education and awareness-raising campaigns.

The Methodological Approach Adopted for the Book

The book used a case study method to gain insights into the practices of businesses using SDGs. The summary outline of the case study template is shown in Table 2. The editors approached a range of potential authors to develop the case studies. They approached early career researchers, PhD students, family business academics, family business consultants, managers of family business centres and

Table 2. Key Aspects of the Case Study Template Used by Authors in This Book.

<i>Vision and mission, services offered by the organisation</i>	<i>How do the vision mission and background of the organisation relate to the particular SDG?</i>
<i>Background to the company</i>	
<i>Historical development</i>	A. When did the SDG become important to the organisation?
A. Founding date	B. Was there a person who championed the SDG?
B. Founder details	C. Are the SDGs explicitly talked about by staff?
C. Human interest angle of the founder	
D. Quotes from the founder or key people	
E. Size of organisation	
<i>How do key stakeholders relate to the SDG championed by the organisation?</i>	<i>Outline the business model of the organisation and add how SDG is important.</i>
A. What stakeholders influence the organisation?	A. Outline key elements
B. Has the adoption of the SDG in the organisation had an impact on stakeholders?	B. An outline structure of the organisation is needed.
C. Have stakeholders influenced the actions of the organisation related to the SDG?	C. Provide a diagram of the business model
	D. Identify key activities and return on investment
	E. How does the SDG relate to return on investment?
	F. How do businesses monitor impacts?
<i>What are the challenges facing the organisation in implementing the SDGs?</i>	<i>How does the organisation see itself in relation to providing benefits outside the organisation? What next for the organisation?</i>
<i>How does the business measure and report on sustainability and SDG activities?</i>	

family business practitioners to consider submitting a case for the book. Interested authors were asked to choose the SDGs that best matched the family business of their choice and use a case study template provided by the editors of the book series to craft a case study on how the family business advanced the particular SDG. A truly global response was received for the book series with participants from all over the globe.

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